

Bluegrass Banjo

Tunes and Techniques

Taught by
Tony Trischka



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Hi,

Welcome to the video. This is primarily an intermediate approach to bluegrass banjo with an emphasis on Scruggs style.

What you'll be learning from the tape and this book of tablature is a distillation of tips, tunes and general approaches that I've absorbed during my thirty years of playing the banjo.

I started giving banjo lessons in 1970 and that really forced me to explore, for the first time, the subtleties of Scruggs style. I'd gotten to the point where I thought I knew how to play like Earl, but I was getting bored with playing the same old licks. Then, when I started to teach, I bought the Scruggs book to figure out what he was doing. The right hand subtleties, exquisite phrasing and surprise chord tactics (i.e. anticipating a chord change by a measure and a half) opened my eyes to the incredible depth of this music.

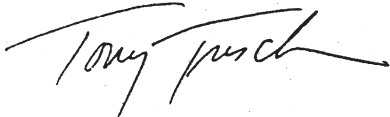
Since then, I've transcribed and learned from countless solos, not only by Earl, but by the other greats who contributed so much to the development of bluegrass banjo.

I've also travelled a great deal and had a chance to spend time with some of these musicians. In a number of cases, they've taught me in a very direct way; put your finger on this fret, slide like this, etc... In other situations it's been more of an osmotic process.

The point is, it's taken me a long time, drawing from many different sources, to learn what I have so far (and I'm still peeling back the layers of the onion). With this project I've tried to organize in one place much of that information. I hope it saves you time getting to the heart of what you want out of your playing.

I'm still excited by this music and I hope some of my enthusiasm can be transmitted to you through this video.

Best of luck,

A handwritten signature in cursive script that reads "Tony Trischka". The signature is fluid and stylized, with a long horizontal flourish extending to the right.

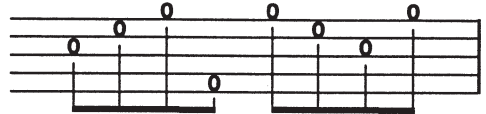
Tony Trischka

Inscribed by
Charyl Roberts

A Word About the Tablature

I'll be using a fairly standard form of tablature. The top line of the staff represents the first string and the bottom line, the fifth string. A number on a line indicates the fret to be fingered by the left hand.

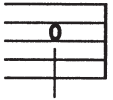
There will be the equivalent of eight (8) eighth notes (connected by single lines) to the measure.



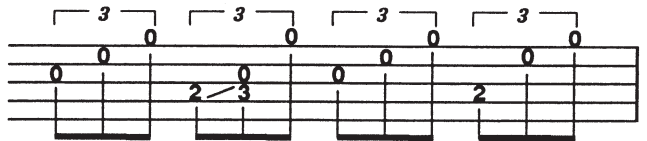
One eighth note = two sixteenth notes (connected by double lines):



Two eighth notes = one quarter note (indicated by an unconnected descending line)



A triplet consists of three evenly spaced notes occupying the same rhythmic space as two notes of the same value. More specifically, an eighth note triplet equals two standard eighth notes. The second break of "Bluegrass Blues" is filled with triplets.



Right Hand fingerings are indicated as letters below the staff and are as follows:

T= thumb

I = index finger

M = middle finger

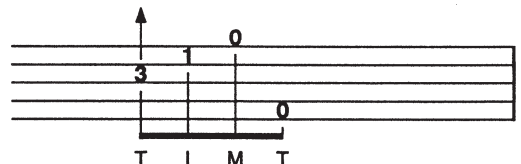
Left hand functions will be represented by the following letters:

P = pull-off

H = hammer-on

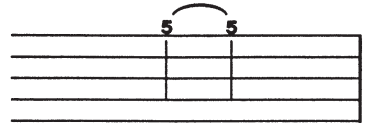
S = slide finger

A choke will be represented by an arrow.

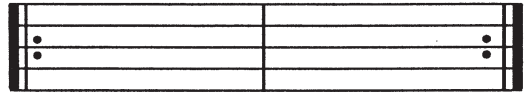


Tablature continued

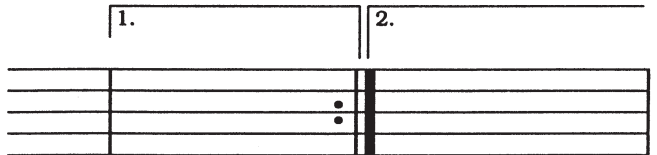
When I double the value of a note, I connect it to itself with an arcing line. Remember, play only the first note and let it ring through the time value of the second. This sounds like a long pause.



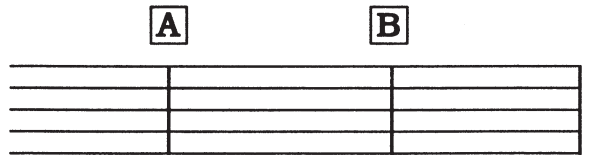
Repeat signs will surround the material to be repeated.



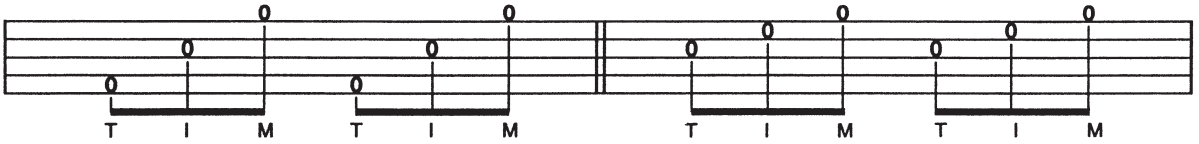
In cases where the repeated material has two different endings, you'll see this:



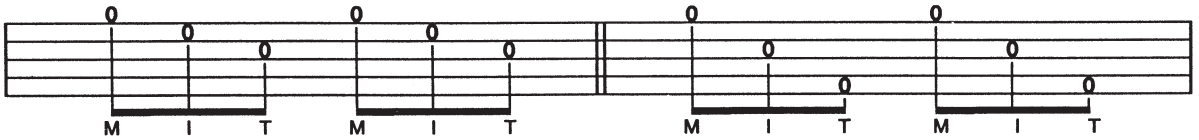
Boxed letters A and B indicate the first and second sections of a tune.



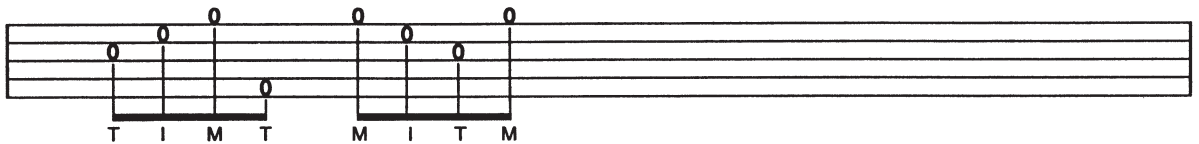
Forward



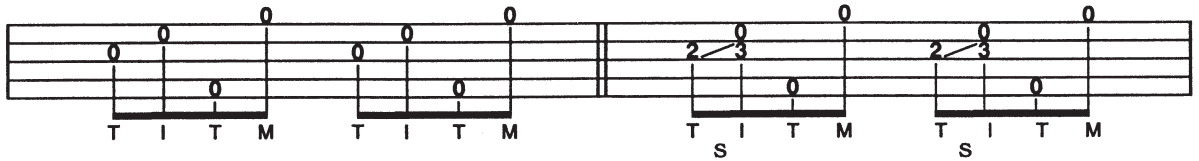
Backward



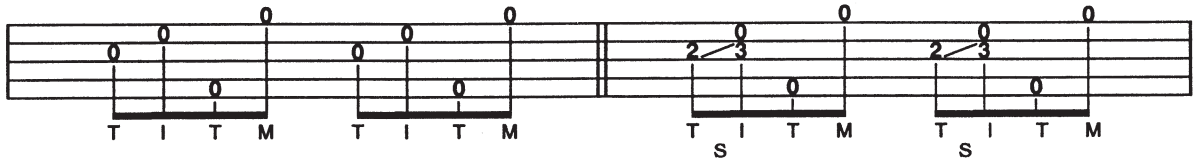
Forward - Backward



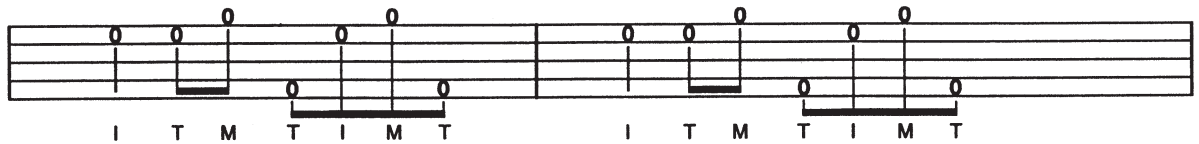
Square



Cripple Creek



Foggy Mountain Breakdown



Foggy Mountain Breakdown Roll With Left Hand



Key Of A
(Capo 2)

Weeping Willow Tree

G **C**

2 0 0 0 2 0 0 2 0 0 3-2 3-2 0 1 2 2

T S I T M S S T P I T P M T

G **D**

1 2 1 2 0 0 0 0 0 1 0 0 0 0 0 0

T I T M T I T M T I T M T I T M T M

G **C**

0 0 0 2-3 3 0 3 0 3 0 0 0 3-2 1 2 2

T I T M T H I T I H M M I T P M T

G **D** **G**

1 2 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0

T T T I T M T M T I S M

Don Reno

G **C**

0 0 0 2-3 3 0 5 0 3 3 4 0 2 0 0 1 0 0

T T I H T I T I T T H I H I

G **D**

0 1 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0

T H I T M T T S T S I T I T I

Weeping Willow Tree

Continued

Chord progression: G, C, C, G, D, G

Notes: 2 0 0 | 2-3 3 0 5 0 | 3 0 4 0 2 0 | 0 0 1 0 0-2 0

Fingering: T I M T H T | I H | T I T I T | T H

Chord progression: C, G, D, G

Notes: 1 0 | 0 0 0 0 0 | 0 0 0 0 0 | 0 2 3 0-2 0 | 0 0 0 0

Fingering: T I M T H T | T T I M T I M T T

A Liza Jane

Chord progression: G, D, G, G

Notes: 5 5 0 2 0 | 2 0 0 0 2 0 | 2-3 0 0 5 5 0 | 0 0 0 0

Fingering: T S | I H M | T S T T T

Chord progression: D, G, G

Notes: 2 0 | 2 0 0 0 3-2 0 | 0 0 0 0 2 4 0 2 0 | 2 4 0 2 0

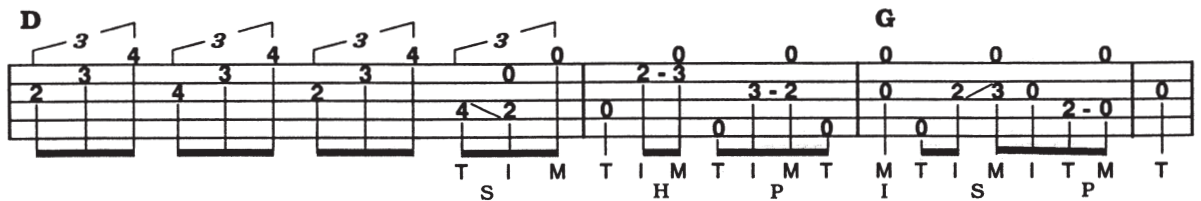
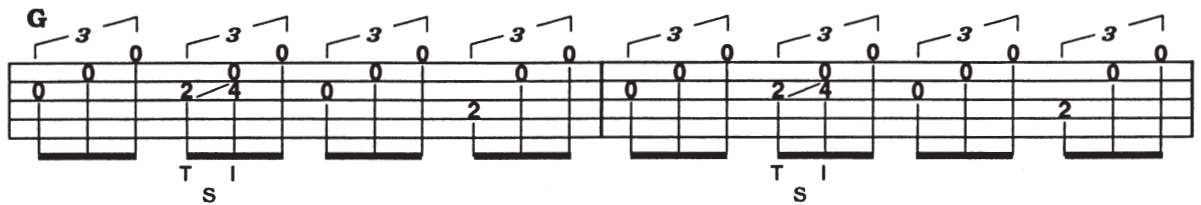
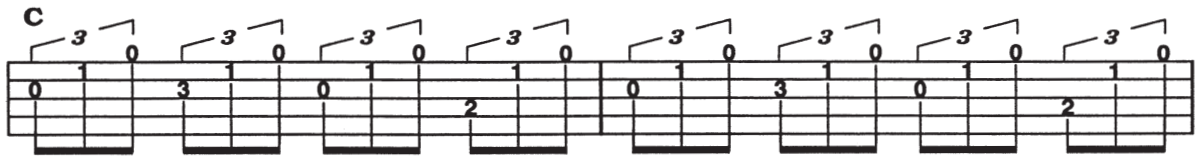
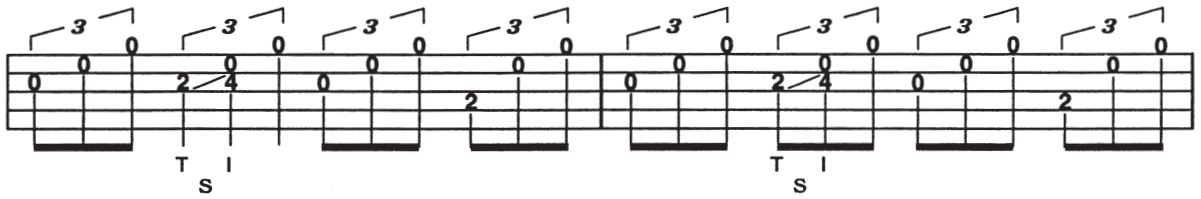
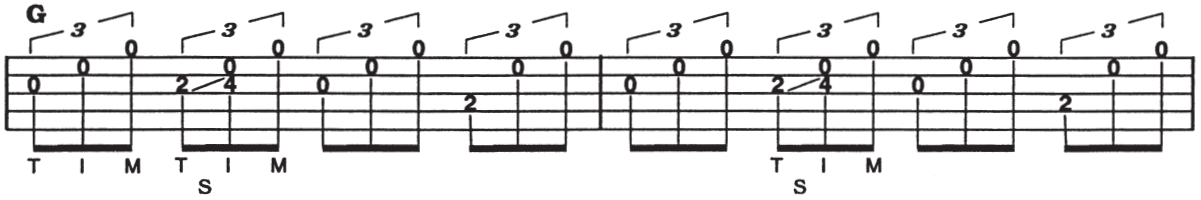
Fingering: T S | T P M T | M I | T S T T T

Chord progression: D, G, G

Notes: 2 4 0 2 0 | 2 0 0 0 3-2 0 | 0 0 0 0 0 0 2 0 | 2 4 0 2 0

Fingering: T S T T T | T S T P M T | M I T S T T T

Bluegrass Blues - Second Break



Licks That Double Fingers

Back-up

F Position Back-up

Walk-up Lick

F Position-D Position

F Position-D Postion Variation

8

In the Mood Lick

G **C**

T I M T I M T I M T I M I T M

D

G

Adding The Thumb

G **C**

D **G**

John Hardy (Down the Neck Sample)

C

I I M

John Hardy (Up the Neck)

A

C

G

C

*** G**

C

G

B

D

G

* John Hardy (Going Up On Your Nails)

Leather Britches

A

Section A of 'Leather Britches' consists of two staves of music. The first staff begins with a repeat sign and a 7/8 time signature. The notes are 8, 9, 7, 9, 8, 8, 7, 8, 9, 7, 8, 0, 7, 8, 9, 7, 8, 9, 8, 3, 2, 0, 0, 0. The second staff continues with notes 7, 8, 9, 7, 8, 9, 8, 7, 8, 9, 10, 8, 9, 7, 8, 0, 3, 2, 0, 0, 0. Fingering numbers are placed above the notes. Below the staves, the letters M, I, M, I, T, M, I, M, I are written, corresponding to the notes.

B

Section B of 'Leather Britches' consists of two staves of music. The first staff begins with a repeat sign and a 2/3 time signature. The notes are 2, 3, 0, 0, 3, 8, 9, 11, 9, 8, 0, 2, 3, 0, 3, 5, 5, 0, 0, 0, 2. The second staff continues with notes 2, 3, 0, 0, 3, 8, 9, 11, 9, 8, 12, 11, 9, 8, 0, 3, 2, 0, 0, 0. Fingering numbers are placed above the notes. Below the staves, the letters T, I, M, I, T, I, T, M, T, I, T, M, I, S are written, corresponding to the notes.

John Henry

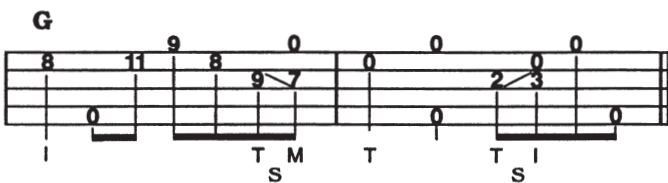
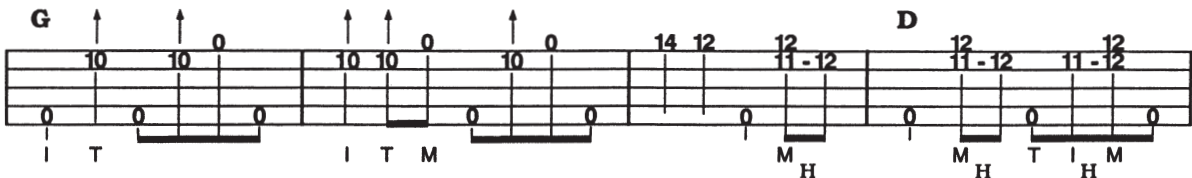
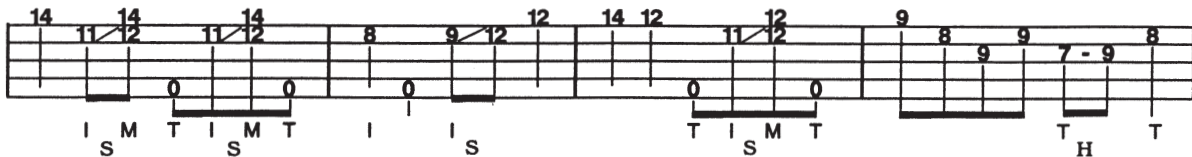
G

Section G of 'John Henry' consists of one staff of music. The notes are 17, 17, 15, 14, 17, 12, 14, 11, 14, 11, 12, 8, 9, 12, 12, 17, 17, 15, 14. Fingering numbers are placed above the notes. Below the staff, the letters M, M, M, I, S, T, I, S, M, T, I, T, I, S are written, corresponding to the notes.

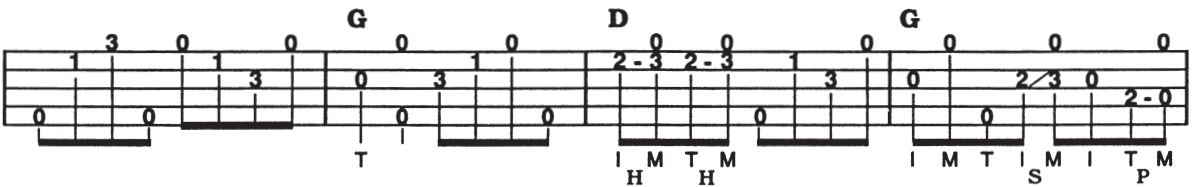
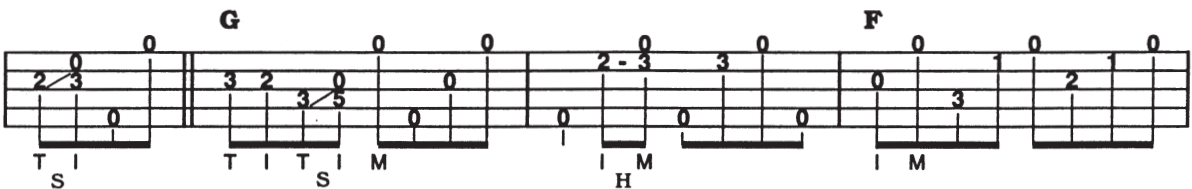
D

G

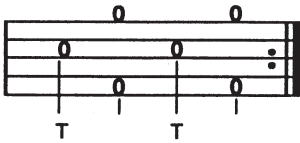
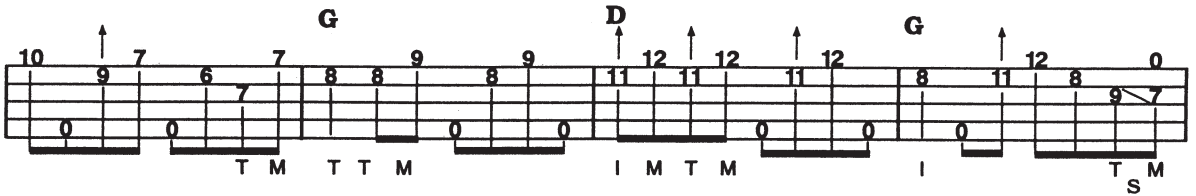
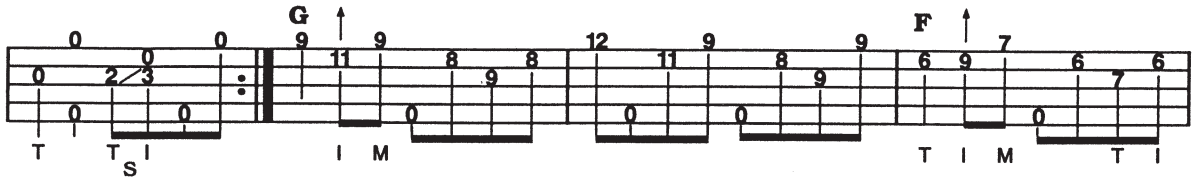
Sections D and G of 'John Henry' consist of one staff of music. The notes are 17, 15, 14, 12, 11, 12, 12, 12, 12, 14, 12, 12, 14, 17, 17, 15, 14, 17, 12. Fingering numbers are placed above the notes. Below the staff, the letters I, M, S are written, corresponding to the notes.



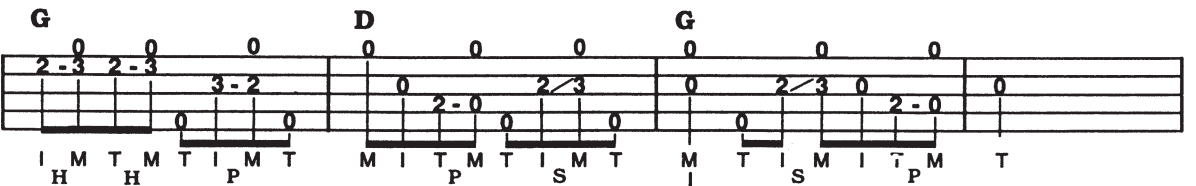
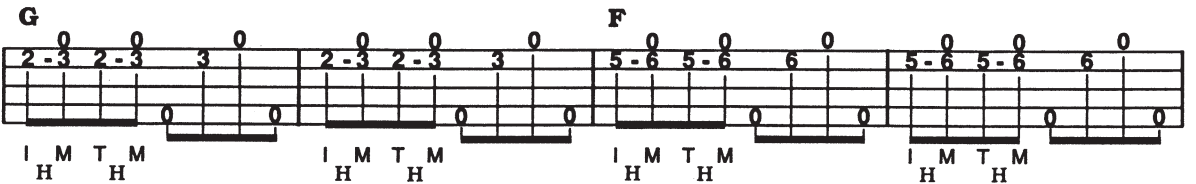
Little Maggie



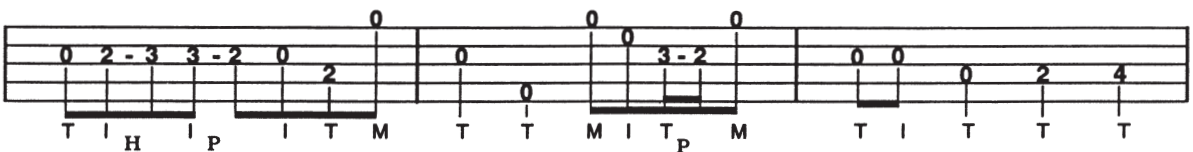
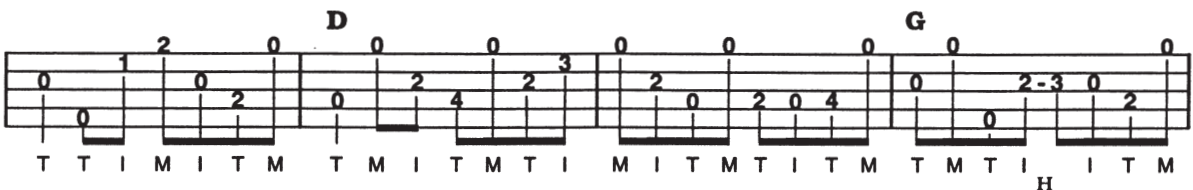
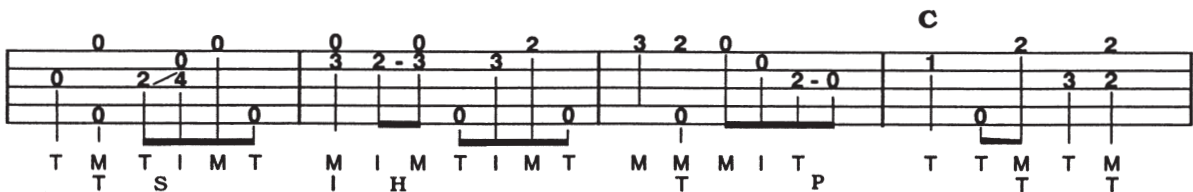
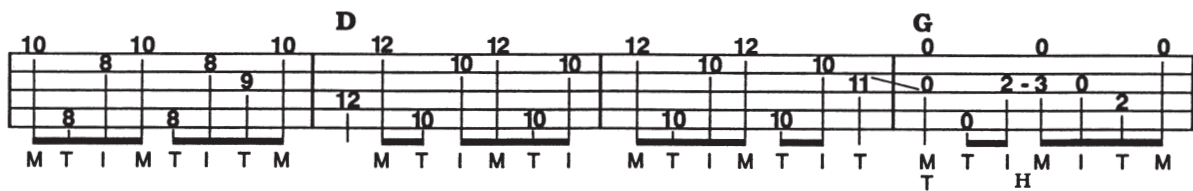
Little Maggie (Up The Neck)



Little Maggie (*improv*)



Backup For "Unfaithful One"



J.D. Crowe's Backup For "Letter From My Darling"

*From a live Recording of the Bluegrass Album Band.
Taped at Leob Student Center, New York City, November 1983*

G

0 2 4 5 5 4 3 5 5 9 9 9 8 12 12 12 14 12 11 12 12 14 12

T T T T M T M T M T T S M T I T M I I M I M M I I M M M I

D

8 8 8 7 8 9 7 8 12 10 12 10 12 16 15 16 15 16 14 15 14 14

I T I T I T T I T M T I T M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I T M

G

14 15 17 15 17 8 9 8 12 14 11 - 12 14 11 12 14 11 - 12 14 11 - 12

T I M T I M T M T T M T I T M M I H M I H M I H M I H M

D G

8 9 7 7 9 12 10 11 8 9 9 - 7 8 7 8 9 7 8 0 9 7 0

I T T I T M T M T M T M T T H M P I T T I T M T I T M T

Cross-eyed Cricket (1st Break)

A C G

0 2 0 1 2 2 1 2 2 0 2 0 0 0 5 0

T T T T T I M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I M

Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: C, G, S.

1.
 2.
 Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: C.

B

 Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: F, C, G, C.

Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: F, C, G, C.

Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: F, C, G, C.

Musical staff with notes and fingerings. Chords indicated: F, C, G, C.

Cross-eyed Cricket (2nd Break)

A

C 10 8 10 10 8 10 10 10 10 8 15 15 0 16 16 17 16 17
 M I T M I T I M T I M T M I S T M I T M T M T M T I M

C 10 8 10 10 8 10 10 10 10 7 8 9 **G** 8 0 7 8 9 **C** 10 8 10 8
 M I T M I T I M T I M T M I S M T I M T M I M T I S M T I M T I T

C 10 8 10 8 10 **B** **F** 10 10 10 10 10 **C** 10 10 10 10 **G** 12 12 12 12
 M T I M T I T M T I M T I M T M T I M T I M T M T I M T I M T M

C 10 10 10 **F** 10 10 10 10 **C** 10 10 10 0 0 0 0
 T I M T I M T M T I M T I M T M T I M T I M T S T M T M T S I M T

C 2 1 2 1 2 **F** 0 - 2 0 - 2 1 **C** 2 2 1 3 0 3 - 2 3 - 2 0 0
 M T I M T I M T H M T H M I T M M T I H M I T P M T P M T M

C 2 1 2 **F** 1 1 1 1 **C** 1 2 0 1 2 3 **G** 0 0 2 3 0 0
 T T I M T I M T M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I M T I

Soldier's Joy

A Tuning: F# D F# A D

First system of music notation for "Soldier's Joy". The staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings (0-2, 0, 0, 0, 2-0, 0-2, 0, 0, 0, 0) and fret numbers (0, 2, 4, 0, 2, 4, 0, 0, 2, 4, 0-4). The notes are labeled with letters: I, H, M, T, I, T, S, M, T, T, S, I, M, T, I, P, M, T, I, P, M, I, T, S, M, T, H, M, I.

Second system of music notation for "Soldier's Joy". The staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings (0-2, 1, 0, 0, 0-2, 0, 0, 0, 0, 2-0, 0, 2-4, 0, 4, 2) and fret numbers (0, 2, 4, 0, 2, 4, 0, 0, 2, 4, 0, 0, 4, 2). The notes are labeled with letters: T, H, T, I, M, T, I, H, M, T, I, T, S, M, T, T, S, I, M, T, I, P, M, T, M, H, I.

Third system of music notation for "Soldier's Joy". The staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings (0, 0, 0, 0-2, 0, 0, 0, 0, 4, 0, 15, 7, 0-2, 2, 2, 4, 5, 2, 4) and fret numbers (0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 4, 0, 15, 7, 0, 2, 2, 4, 5, 2, 4). The notes are labeled with letters: I, H, M, I, T, M, H, T, M.

Fourth system of music notation for "Soldier's Joy". The staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings (0, 5, 7, 0, 0, 7, 7, 7, 7, 5, 0, 0, 5, 7, 0-2, 2, 2, 4, 5, 2) and fret numbers (0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0). The notes are labeled with letters: I, M, T, I, T, S, M, I, T, T, H, T.

Fifth system of music notation for "Soldier's Joy". The staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings (2-4, 0, 4, 2, 0, 0, 0, 0, 4, 0, 0, 0, 0-2, 0) and fret numbers (0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0). The notes are labeled with letters: M, H, T, I, H, M.

Endings

G

The first staff contains 11 measures of music. The first measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '2' above it. The second measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The third measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The fourth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The fifth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The sixth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The seventh measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The eighth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The ninth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The tenth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The eleventh measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it.

The second staff contains 11 measures of music. The first measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '2' above it. The second measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The third measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The fourth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The fifth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The sixth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The seventh measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The eighth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The ninth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The tenth measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it. The eleventh measure has a G note on the 3rd string, 2nd fret, with a '0' above it.